

DSAT Reading & Writing — Main Idea — SOLUTIONS

25 Original Practice Questions | Easy · Medium · Hard

Q1. [Easy]

Correct Answer: D

REASONING: The passage describes Amara arriving at the village and recognizing nothing. She expected familiarity but found the village 'distant and unfamiliar,' as though her memories belonged to someone else. The main idea is the disconnect between her memories and the current reality.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) The passage does not mention regret about leaving; it focuses on the mismatch between memory and reality.
- B) While the passage mentions rust on roofs, the main focus is on Amara's inability to recognize the place—not physical deterioration specifically.
- C) There is no mention of the grandmother concealing anything; the change is presented as natural and surprising to Amara.

TRAP ALERT: Option B is tempting because the passage does describe aging houses, but the main idea centers on Amara's emotional experience of non-recognition, not on the village's physical decline.

KEY INSIGHT: Main idea = what the *WHOLE* passage is about, not just one detail. The passage builds toward the final sentence about memory.

FAST METHOD: Ask: What does the last sentence emphasize? The disconnect between memory and reality points to C.

Q2. [Easy]

Correct Answer: D

REASONING: The passage introduces tardigrades' resilience and then explains how they achieve it: cryptobiosis, which drops metabolic activity to near-undetectable levels. This is the central point.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) The passage says tardigrades 'can tolerate' the vacuum of space but does not claim they are the only organisms that can.
- B) The passage does not discuss tardigrades' geographic distribution.
- C) The passage describes cryptobiosis but does not claim tardigrade metabolism is fundamentally different from all other animals.

TRAP ALERT: Option A uses an extreme word ('only') that should be a red flag. The passage never makes this exclusive claim.

KEY INSIGHT: Watch for answer choices that go beyond what the text actually states—especially words like 'only,' 'all,' or 'every.'

FAST METHOD: The passage structure is: fact (resilience) → explanation (cryptobiosis). The main idea links both.

Q3. [Easy]

Correct Answer: B

REASONING: The passage reports survey findings: 68% preferred hybrid, citing social interaction and flexibility. This is directly captured by option B.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) The passage does not mention productivity at all.
- C) The passage discusses workers' preferences, not employer mandates.
- D) Commuting is mentioned as one advantage of working from home, but the passage does not call it the 'single greatest source of dissatisfaction.'

TRAP ALERT: Option D distorts a supporting detail (reduced commuting) into the main idea. Always distinguish supporting details from the central claim.

KEY INSIGHT: For survey-based passages, the main idea typically captures the key finding, not a secondary data point.

FAST METHOD: The first sentence states the key finding (68% prefer hybrid). The correct answer should mirror that.

Q4. [Easy]

Correct Answer: B

REASONING: The passage explains that the Rosetta Stone's Greek inscription served as a key to decipher the other two scripts, unlocking the Egyptian writing system.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) The passage does not compare the Stone's significance to other discoveries or call it 'the most significant.'
- C) The passage mentions Greek on the Stone but does not discuss Greek as a spoken language more broadly.
- D) The passage does not compare the complexity of the Demotic and hieroglyphic scripts.

TRAP ALERT: Option A uses superlative language ('most significant') that the passage never employs.

KEY INSIGHT: Be wary of options that make ranking or superlative claims the passage does not support.

FAST METHOD: Identify the causal chain: Greek was readable → used as key → deciphered Egyptian scripts. Option B captures this.

Q5. [Easy]

Correct Answer: C

REASONING: The passage introduces coral reefs as biodiversity hotspots (one quarter of marine species), then discusses the threat of rising temperatures causing bleaching. Both points are captured in option C.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) Algae are mentioned as part of the bleaching process, not as the sole source of reef color in general.
- B) The passage does not mention any new species discoveries.
- D) The passage states coral reefs cover less than one percent of the ocean floor, not more than expected.

TRAP ALERT: Option D directly contradicts the passage. Always re-read to confirm direction (less vs. more).

KEY INSIGHT: Main idea often connects two halves of a passage: the 'what' (biodiversity) and the 'so what' (threat).

FAST METHOD: Two-part passages → look for the answer that joins both parts.

Q6. [Easy]

Correct Answer: A

REASONING: Kenji launches paper boats daily knowing they will disintegrate, yet the ritual gives him 'a quiet permission to hope.' The main idea is the hope embedded in a futile ritual.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- B) Kenji is not described as frustrated; he knowingly accepts the boats will not reach the sea.
- C) Nothing in the passage connects the boats to a career aspiration.
- D) Neighbors are not mentioned in the passage.

TRAP ALERT: Option B misreads the passage tone. Kenji 'knew, of course' the boats would disintegrate—this is acceptance, not frustration.

KEY INSIGHT: Pay attention to the emotional tone of the final sentence; it often holds the key to the main idea in literary passages.

FAST METHOD: Final sentence = 'quiet permission to hope.' Match that to the answer choices.

Q7. [Easy]

Correct Answer: C

REASONING: The passage defines the zone of proximal development as the gap between independent and guided ability, and states effective teaching operates within this zone. Option C captures this.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) Vygotsky argued for guided learning, the opposite of 'without adult intervention.'
- B) The passage does not single out gifted students.
- D) The passage discusses Vygotsky's theory, not specific experiments comparing peer and teacher instruction.

TRAP ALERT: Option A directly contradicts the passage. Eliminating contradictions first is the fastest strategy.

KEY INSIGHT: For concept-definition passages, the main idea = the concept + its key implication.

FAST METHOD: Vygotsky's concept is about guided instruction in the right zone. Only B matches.

Q8. [Medium]

Correct Answer: D

REASONING: The passage starts with the traditional two-partner model of lichen and then reveals that genomic studies show additional organisms (yeasts, bacteria), suggesting greater complexity. The main idea is that lichen biology is more complex than previously thought.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) This captures only the traditional model and ignores the new research that is the passage's focus.
- B) The passage says yeasts 'contribute to chemical defenses' but does not rank them as more important than algae.
- C) The passage does not discuss whether fungi can survive independently.

TRAP ALERT: Option A describes a supporting detail (fungal structure), not the main idea. The passage pivots at 'Recent genomic studies have complicated this picture.'

KEY INSIGHT: When a passage has a 'but' or 'however' pivot, the main idea usually lives after the pivot.

FAST METHOD: Find the pivot word ('complicated this picture') → the main idea is about new complexity.

Q9. [Medium]

Correct Answer: A

REASONING: The passage identifies two drivers of the Great Migration (economic opportunity and fleeing Jim Crow) and its cultural impact (Harlem Renaissance). Option A captures both the causes and the consequences.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- B) The passage mentions the Harlem Renaissance as one outcome, not the 'most important cultural achievement' of the century.
- C) 'Universally found better conditions' is too strong; the passage says opportunity was a motivator but does not claim universal success.
- D) 'Sole reason' is too narrow; the passage names both economic and social factors.

TRAP ALERT: Options C and D use extreme language ('universally,' 'sole') that the passage avoids.

KEY INSIGHT: Correct main idea answers tend to be moderate and comprehensive; wrong answers tend to be extreme or narrow.

FAST METHOD: Count the passage's points: (1) economic factors, (2) Jim Crow, (3) cultural impact. Only A covers all three.

Q10. [Medium]

Correct Answer: C

REASONING: Sofia keeps reworking the painting because she sees only 'what was missing'—the ideal she imagines but cannot achieve. Others praise it, but she is unsatisfied. The main idea is the gap between artistic vision and execution.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) The professor praised the work and classmates offered to buy it—they clearly appreciate it.
- B) Sofia shows no intention of selling; she keeps reworking the painting.
- D) The passage does not suggest Sofia lacks training; her dissatisfaction is personal and aesthetic.

TRAP ALERT: Option A reverses the passage's meaning. Re-read: others praise the painting; Sofia alone is dissatisfied.

KEY INSIGHT: In literary passages, the character's internal experience is usually the main idea, not others' reactions.

FAST METHOD: The key phrase is 'the shade of blue she could imagine but not mix'—the vision-reality gap. That is B.

Q11. [Medium]

Correct Answer: B

REASONING: The passage explains two cell types (chromatophores and iridophores) and how they work together to produce camouflage. The main idea is the sophistication of this multi-layered system.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) 'All marine animals' is far too broad; the passage discusses cephalopods specifically.
- C) The passage focuses on camouflage, not mate attraction.
- D) The passage provides a clear explanation of the mechanism, so scientists are not 'unable to explain' it.

TRAP ALERT: Option A generalizes beyond cephalopods to 'all marine animals.' Watch for scope expansion in wrong answers.

KEY INSIGHT: Main idea must match the passage's scope. If the passage is about cephalopods, the answer should be too.

FAST METHOD: The last sentence summarizes: 'one of the most sophisticated camouflage systems.' Match to B.

Q12. [Medium]

Correct Answer: D

REASONING: The passage presents Nakamura's finding that defaults shape behavior (saving 40% more) and her argument that this challenges rational-choice theory. Option D captures both the finding and its theoretical implication.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) 'Universally preferred' is not stated; the passage reports savings outcomes, not preferences.
- B) 'Entirely discredited' is too extreme; Nakamura challenges one assumption, not the entire field.
- C) The passage does not mention salary differences.

TRAP ALERT: Option B exaggerates the scope of Nakamura's claim. She challenges an assumption, not all of classical economics.

KEY INSIGHT: Extreme language in answer choices ('entirely,' 'universally,' 'all') is almost always wrong on main idea questions.

FAST METHOD: Two-part passage: finding (defaults matter) + implication (challenges rational-choice). Only B has both.

Q13. [Medium]

Correct Answer: C

REASONING: The passage describes New Zealand as the first to grant women's suffrage, credits Sheppard's petitions, and notes that the right to stand for parliament came 26 years later. Option C captures the achievement, the activism, and the limitation.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) 'Single-handedly' overstates; the passage says Sheppard organized petitions with 32,000 signatures, implying broad support.
- B) The passage says New Zealand's achievement 'inspired suffrage movements worldwide,' the opposite of 'less effective.'
- D) The passage does not describe opposition from the male population.

TRAP ALERT: Option A distorts the passage by attributing everything to one person and ignoring the collective effort.

KEY INSIGHT: Be alert to choices that over-attribute agency to a single individual when the passage describes a movement.

FAST METHOD: The passage has three points: (1) first to grant suffrage, (2) Sheppard's activism, (3) parliament rights delayed. B covers all three.

Q14. [Medium]

Correct Answer: A

REASONING: The passage describes fungal networks facilitating carbon transfer to seedlings but notes that fungi retain nutrients as 'payment.' The main idea captures both the sharing and the fungi's benefit.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- B) 'Cannot survive' is too absolute; the passage says seedlings received up to 30% of carbon this way, not that they depend on it entirely.
- C) Tanaka cautions against calling the transfer 'purely altruistic,' meaning trees are not intentionally sharing.
- D) The fungi are described as intermediaries that benefit, not parasites that harm.

TRAP ALERT: Option C contradicts the passage's emphasis on the non-altruistic nature of the exchange.

KEY INSIGHT: When a passage includes a caveat ('however,' 'cautions'), the main idea should reflect that nuance.

FAST METHOD: Passage = sharing happens + fungi benefit too. Only A has both elements.

Q15. [Medium]

Correct Answer: B

REASONING: The poem describes baking as triggering vivid sensory memories of the mother's kitchen. The speaker steps into the mother's kitchen, not their own, when opening the flour tin.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) There is no mention of regret about not writing down recipes.
- C) The tone is nostalgic and warm, not tedious.
- D) The passage does not mention a professional bakery.

TRAP ALERT: Option A introduces a detail (documenting recipes) not present in the poem. Never choose an answer that adds information the text does not contain.

KEY INSIGHT: In poetry passages, focus on the emotional arc. Here it moves from observation to memory to presence.

FAST METHOD: Final image: 'it is her kitchen I step into, not my own.' The main idea is memory evoked through baking.

Q16. [Medium]

Correct Answer: D

REASONING: The passage describes a feedback loop (less funding → deterioration → less use → harder to argue for funding) and Espinoza's proposed solution (equitable per-capita allocation). Option D captures both the problem and the solution.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) The passage says parks in low-income areas receive less maintenance, not that they lack parks entirely.
- B) Espinoza discusses funding disparities, not usage rates among wealthy residents specifically.
- C) The passage implies parks do affect quality of life; otherwise, the funding gap would not matter.

TRAP ALERT: Option A exaggerates: 'lack parks entirely' vs. 'receive less maintenance funding.' Read precisely.

KEY INSIGHT: Problem-solution passages: the main idea should include both the problem and the proposed solution.

FAST METHOD: Identify the cycle and the fix. Only B mentions both.

Q17. [Medium]

Correct Answer: D

REASONING: The passage explains predictable glass fracture patterns and then describes their forensic applications. The main idea links the scientific regularity to practical use.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) The passage discusses fracture patterns, not shatter-resistant glass manufacturing.
- B) The passage says radial cracks form first; it does not rank which type is more forensically useful.
- C) The passage explicitly describes forensic applications, contradicting 'no practical applications.'

TRAP ALERT: Option C directly contradicts the passage. Always eliminate answers that conflict with stated information.

KEY INSIGHT: Science passages often follow a pattern: phenomenon → application. The main idea should capture both.

FAST METHOD: Last sentence = forensic application. First half = predictable patterns. A connects them.

Q18. [Hard]

Correct Answer: B

REASONING: The passage presents El-Amin's challenge to the accretion model, her alternative hypothesis (gravitational collapse), and notes the hypothesis 'remains contentious.' Option B captures all three elements: challenge, debate, and lack of full acceptance.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) 'Proven conclusively' overstates; the passage says the hypothesis 'remains contentious.'
- C) The passage discusses formation mechanisms, not the age of the solar system.
- D) El-Amin suggests overlap for some rocky planets; she does not claim the mechanisms are 'identical' for all.

TRAP ALERT: Option A is the most tempting wrong answer because it aligns with El-Amin's view but overstates certainty. The word 'conclusively' is the red flag.

KEY INSIGHT: Hard main idea questions often hinge on degree of certainty. Match the passage's hedging ('contentious,' 'may') to the answer.

FAST METHOD: Check each answer for certainty level. 'Proven conclusively' vs. 'remains contentious' → eliminate A immediately.

Q19. [Hard]

Correct Answer: C

REASONING: Whitfield argues tests capture socioeconomic variance, not school quality, and advocates value-added models. Option C includes both the critique and the recommendation.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) Whitfield argues affluent schools score higher because of demographics, not better methods. Independent evaluators rated lower-income schools' methods highly.
- B) Whitfield does not reject assessment; she advocates a different kind (value-added models).
- D) Independent evaluators are cited as credible (they rated lower-income schools' methods highly), not as unreliable.

TRAP ALERT: Option B misrepresents Whitfield's position: she wants better assessment, not no assessment. Look for 'not X, but Y' structures in the passage.

KEY INSIGHT: When a passage says 'does not reject X entirely; rather, she advocates Y,' the main idea must include Y.

FAST METHOD: Last sentence holds the proposed solution (value-added models). Any answer missing it is incomplete.

Q20. [Hard]

Correct Answer: A

REASONING: The cartographer maps endangered places as preservation, and he reinterprets his colleagues' 'sentimental' label as a failure of courage/empathy. Option A captures both the motivation and the response to criticism.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- B) The passage does not suggest he seeks professional recognition; he maps places others overlook.
- C) The passage describes the maps as 'acts of preservation,' not as inaccurate. While the passage does state the cartographer drew maps 'not of places he had been,' nothing suggests the resulting maps are flawed — the claim of inaccuracy is unsupported by the text.
- D) The development authority is marking places for draining, not hiring him to document them.

TRAP ALERT: Option C misreads 'places he feared would vanish' as 'places he has never been.' The first phrase is about future disappearance, not past experience.

KEY INSIGHT: Literary main ideas often combine action (what the character does) with motivation (why).

FAST METHOD: Two key phrases: 'act of preservation' and 'dismiss what they lacked the courage to feel.' Both appear in A.

Q21. [Hard]

Correct Answer: B

REASONING: The passage describes metabolic flexibility (switching between sulfur and hydrogen oxidation) and Nwankwo's suggestion that this explains rapid recovery after volcanic disturbances. Option B links flexibility to resilience.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) 'Exclusively on sulfur oxidation' contradicts the passage, which emphasizes switching between sulfur and hydrogen oxidation.
- C) The passage discusses chemosynthesis at vents, not photosynthesis.
- D) 'Only deep-sea environments' is too restrictive; the passage does not make this claim.

TRAP ALERT: Option A directly contradicts the passage's central finding (metabolic flexibility). Wrong answers sometimes present the opposite of the passage's claim.

KEY INSIGHT: When a passage describes adaptability, the correct main idea will link that adaptability to an outcome.

FAST METHOD: Key word: 'flexibility' → outcome: 'recover more rapidly.' Only B connects them.

Q22. [Hard]

Correct Answer: C

REASONING: Dubois argues the press was 'necessary but insufficient'; democratization required declining paper costs, rising literacy, and lending libraries over two centuries. Option C captures the nuanced argument.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) The passage does not discuss when the press was invented.
- B) 'Negligible impact' is too extreme; Dubois calls the press 'necessary,' just not sufficient alone.
- D) Lending libraries are one of several factors mentioned, not the sole focus of Dubois's research.

TRAP ALERT: Option B exaggerates by saying 'negligible impact.' Dubois calls the press 'necessary'—she acknowledges its importance while adding nuance.

KEY INSIGHT: Hard questions often test whether you can distinguish 'not sufficient alone' from 'not important at all.'

FAST METHOD: The phrase 'necessary but insufficient' is the thesis. Only A mirrors that balanced claim.

Q23. [Hard]

Correct Answer: A

REASONING: Zhou's research reframes code-switching from a deficiency to a strategic, skilled practice. The passage explicitly concludes it is 'an expression of' linguistic competence, not a breakdown of it.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- B) The passage discusses strategic switching, not preference for one language.
- C) This is the view Zhou explicitly challenges, not the one she supports.
- D) The passage focuses on code-switching, not language endangerment or documentation.

TRAP ALERT: Option C presents the old, discredited view as though it were the passage's conclusion. Always check whether an answer aligns with the passage's final position, not the view it is refuting.

KEY INSIGHT: Passages that refute an old view: the main idea is the NEW view, not the old one.

FAST METHOD: Last sentence: 'not a breakdown... but rather an expression of [competence].' That is A.

Q24. [Hard]

Correct Answer: A

REASONING: Osei's mouse experiments suggest epigenetic inheritance across generations, but he cautions against direct extrapolation to humans. Option A captures both the finding and the qualification.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- B) 'Conclusively proven' and 'human parents' overstate; Osei studied mice and urges caution.
- C) Epigenetic changes affect gene expression without altering the DNA sequence—the passage states this.
- D) Osei urges caution but does not say animal studies are irrelevant; they provide suggestive evidence.

TRAP ALERT: Option B is tempting because it sounds like a strong conclusion, but the passage explicitly says 'extrapolating to humans requires caution.' Match the passage's hedging.

KEY INSIGHT: When a passage includes a caveat in the final sentence, the correct answer must include that caveat.

FAST METHOD: Two-part structure: finding (epigenetic inheritance in mice) + caveat (caution re humans). Only A has both.

Q25. [Hard]

Correct Answer: A

REASONING: The keeper records weather because measurements are precise and unambiguous ('said exactly what it meant'), unlike people's words, which carry second meanings she cannot parse. The main idea links the ritual to her need for certainty.

WHY EACH WRONG OPTION IS WRONG:

- B) The passage does not mention resentment toward automation; she continues voluntarily.
- C) 'Unauthorized scientific research' is not mentioned; she records weather for personal comfort.
- D) The logbook is for her own use, not for communication with ships.

TRAP ALERT: Option B introduces 'resentment' and 'refuses to abandon her post,' neither of which appears in the passage. Wrong answers for literary passages often invent emotions or motivations.

KEY INSIGHT: The contrast structure (measurement vs. human communication) reveals the main idea: the keeper values clarity.

FAST METHOD: Final sentence: 'The logbook, at least, said exactly what it meant.' This is about certainty vs. ambiguity → A.

TOPIC SUMMARY

Top 3 Mistakes:

- Choosing an answer that captures only one detail rather than the passage's overall point.
- Selecting an option with extreme language ('only,' 'all,' 'never,' 'conclusively') when the passage uses hedging.
- Confusing the OLD view being refuted with the author's actual claim (especially in passages with a pivot).

Top 3 Rules:

- The main idea must cover the WHOLE passage, not just one sentence or paragraph.
- Look for pivot words ('however,' 'but,' 'yet') — the main idea usually lives after the pivot.
- Eliminate answers that go beyond, contradict, or narrow what the text actually says.

Expected Frequency per Module: 2–4 Main Idea questions per module (appears in both Module 1 and Module 2).